was scrapped. So were the 2023 and 2025 backlog exams due in August. The remaining three members of the JPSC resigned, emptying out the commission. But it took another week—and an intervention by Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, who was himself forced to move beyond extending solidarity—before the last act could be written.

Logistically, Soren faces a sprawling mess. It's one thing to have cancelled this year's JPSC prelims. But one of the latest papers to be scrapped, the 2024 Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission's Combined Graduate Level (JSSC CGL) exam, is another kettle of fish. Held in September that year, its cancellation leaves the fate of 1,932 successful candidates hanging—they could lose jobs they had already secured. Appointment letters were issued to them in December 2025, and they have since been serving in Group B and C posts: secretariat assistants, block officials et al. As could be predicted, they have begun protesting and are expected to challenge the decision in court.

SPREADING HEADACHE

But how did it get caught up in the present uproar? The controversy had begun with the 14th JPSC Combined Civil Services Exam. Its last cycle, in 2024, had been a messy affair: a cloud over question paper handling as well as answers, protests, litigation, delayed results. Khiangte, the Mizoram-origin, Jharkhand-cadre IAS alumnus who had just retired as chief secretary, was named JPSC head in early 2025 precisely to help bring order. But the next one proved even more calamitous.

This year, when April 19 was declared as exam day, it was deemed too rushed—students barely had 40 days, a highly compressed one-third of the usual window, to master a huge syllabus. Then, on the night of July 2, came the results—2,204 candidates had passed, and given a mere 17 days to compete for 103 posts at the Mains. Within days, odd details started getting noticed. The qualifying cutoffs for various quota categories had been withheld, so all were in the dark about which candidate had secured passing marks. Some sheets didn't carry every JPSC member's sign. Then, a leaked OMR answer sheet of a qualifying candidate went viral: it showed only 48 out of 200 questions answered, yet the candidate had cleared the exam. All hell broke loose.

On July 21, the CID arrested eight people, including a deputy examination controller and personnel of Lucknow-based TSR Data Processing Private Limited (TDPL), to which critical back-end operations had been outsourced—from OMR-sheet evaluation to result compilation. The next day, Khiangte stepped down—and spent the following fortnight answering tough questions himself. The focus was entirely around how and why TDPL was signed up for the job—by nomination, without a competitive tender. The real red flag: it had been blacklisted for three years by the JSSC in 2024, for irregularities related to that year's JSSC CGL.



Takeaways

- **Soren gives in to all but one demand: a CBI probe**
- **JPSC chief arrested, all exams since '14 under lens**
- **2024 exam cancelled, recruits now protesting**

That exam, too, had faced allegations of mass, organised cheating. In a report submitted in March 2025, the state CID had said that it found answer keys to a staggering 120 out of 150 questions were dictated via landline—to bypass an Internet ban—and circulated on WhatsApp. Yet, that bombshell report was suppressed, and a secondary probe allowed the now-impugned JSSC recruitment to go through. And TDPL was hired again to handle the state civil service exam cycle. Khiangte now faces the charge of having accepted a substantial bribe for the contract.

SELF-SERVING AGENCY

The effect on the JPSC prelims was predictable. Digital records were allegedly altered at TDPL's end to inflate the scores of favoured candidates. The probe reveals sordid details. Rakshak Singh, a TDPL employee, allegedly manipulated his own OMR and cleared the examination! It now transpires that Abhay Tiwari, a former TDPL marketing manager, was selected as a Block Supply Officer in Poreyahat, Godda, after clearing the JSSC CGL. Investigators say he cleared around 12 exams in 13 years, including state and central ones—a record he allegedly used to guarantee outcomes to those willing to pay. He's also alleged to have acted as a crucial link in the entire chain.

Nine competitive examinations in which TDPL was involved have now been scrapped. Soren has also given in to the demand for an Enforcement Directorate probe, a fast-track court and an expert committee on recruitment reforms. But there's one demand he has not yet acceded to: a CBI probe. On August 17, the students were split into two groups: while Mahto and a section of the original agitators ended their stir and celebrated their success, another section took two days, until Soren's capitulation, to call off their sit-in at Ranchi's Jaipal Munda Stadium. The political stakes made that inevitable.

As an Opposition-ruled state, the agitation received a different treatment. Unlike at Jantar Mantar, the BJP was in solidarity with the protesters—its leader, Babulal Marandi, even reprised Rahul's protest mode with a sit-in outside Soren's residence. For Soren, the demand for a CBI probe is inevitably coloured by that. He has reason to be wary of federal agencies, having spent five months in Birsa Munda Central Jail before the 2024 general election. ■